

Vishada Yoga: The Dejection of Arjuna

A condensed rendering of Swami Krishnananda's commentary on Chapter One of the Bhagavadgita

The Gita as a Graduated Spiritual Method

The Bhagavadgita is not a historical narrative but a concentrated system of meditation. It meets the seeker exactly at the level where they stand at any given moment, and raises them stage by stage to the next — there is no sudden jump, no “double promotion,” in its method.

Why the Battlefield: Realism Before Idealism

The Gita is taught on a battlefield rather than in a temple or monastery because spiritual life is not an idealism postponed to future attainment but a realism of the present moment. However far the mind soars toward the transcendent, the feet remain sunk in the mire of physical existence — we cannot jump out of our own skin. The teaching is therefore set in the worst conceivable condition, so that the highest truth is inseparable from present fact: it is as if from hell we rise to the highest heaven.

Sentiment Overriding Reason

Chapter One presents the conflicts of human society and shows the otherwise resolute seeker suddenly ruled by emotion rather than reason. When Arjuna asks Krishna to place the chariot between the two armies, Krishna does not merely comply — he says, “Look at the Kurus arrayed before you,” a word chosen and timed to strike deep. “Kuru” names the common ancestral line of both Kauravas and Pandavas: the same blood runs through both armies, and the word instantly summons a feeling of kinship even toward those Arjuna hates. Blood relation carries a biological intensity that outlasts dislike — a mother loves her child partly because her own substance flows through it, loving herself in loving the child — and this same intensity attaches to every blood relation.

Arjuna's Specific Conflict

Arjuna hated the Kauravas enough to wish them dead, yet could not forget that they were his nephews, brethren, and teachers — Bhishma, on whose lap he had sat as an infant; Drona, the master archer whose training had made Pandava victory possible. Since ingratitude is reckoned the worst of sins, the name “Kuru” stirred this biological sentiment of affection strongly enough to override the rational, military resolve with which Arjuna had entered the field.

The Primacy of the Present Predicament

Understanding where one actually stands matters more than anticipating what should follow; forgetting the present condition weakens the very base from which further ascent must occur. Every step in spiritual life, however small, must be firm: a hurried step often has to be retraced, so a firm step taken slowly — even over years — is preferable to a fast but unstable one.

The World as Not-Other



connects to discourse 1's concept that we are shaped by all our externalities, we are not isolated.

The Pandavas facing the Kauravas represent the spiritual seeker facing the whole world: the Kauravas stand for objective sentiment, the world as object; the Pandavas for subjective sentiment, the seeker as subject. But the subject cannot treat the world as wholly alien, because it is not alien — the same blood that ran through the Pandavas ran through the Kauravas. The individual is a content of the world, so every reality found in the world exists, in miniature, within one's own personality. What looks like a battle against an external world turns out to be a battle against oneself, since the forces assumed to be "outside" are actually within. The three gunas of prakriti — sattva, rajas, tamas — constitute both the world and the mind that perceives it, so the perceiver is made of the same stuff as the perceived. Recognizing this produces fright and diffidence.

The Later Crisis of the Advanced Seeker

Honest seekers, years into practice, begin to feel an inner fear and tremor from questions that did not arise earlier, when the object to be conquered was wrongly assumed wholly external. Years of meditation, life under a Guru, and austerities gradually expose these inner components of one's own nature, until an unfamiliar dread takes hold. Arjuna's doubts, as presented here, recur in every advanced seeker.

Three Doubts

The first is ethical: is it proper to fight against the very constituents that also make up oneself — against one's own family? A family attacking itself is a house divided against itself; it resembles patricide or homicide, condemned in any ethical court.

The second is the doubt of desertion: "Am I deserting the world for God? Do I have no duty toward suffering people?" A little spiritual enlightenment is like a half-baked pot that breaks when water is poured into it — it can shatter a seeker's resolve toward God and redirect them instead into becoming a "saviour of the world," founding centres and gathering devotees, mistaking outward activity for a fulfilled mission. This is the same logic as Arjuna's: the world's claim of kinship feels too real simply to attack and destroy.

The third is despondency over attainment: after decades of practice, what has actually been achieved? If forty years brought nothing, there is no guarantee twenty more will — perhaps some error has been made. A friend who had spent twenty years founding a nearby ashram once asked, in evident distress, whether these teachings were even true; his nerves broke down under the strain, he suffered a heart attack, and doubt of God's very existence has left him in a broken condition.

Why the World Ignores Beginners but Resists the Determined

This is not a beginner's problem but an advanced one. The world does not fear a beginner — an elephant ignores a fly but takes notice of a lion — because a few years of japa or meditation do not touch even the fringe of life's reality. But once a seeker is genuinely determined, the world shows its teeth and claws: buried emotions are stirred, renunciation collapses into unfulfilled subconscious longing, and petty desires

surface. A formerly wealthy renunciate may, after decades of austerity, eat more than he ever did at home and crave trivial things like a wristwatch or a radio. Individual, petty sentiments manifest only once social sentiment — the buffer of being embedded in and respected by society — is suppressed or removed.

Self-Knowledge Requires Standing Outside Society

While comfortably placed within society and respected by all, one cannot know one's own real nature. Self-knowledge requires either that society reject the individual or the individual reject society; only then, standing alone, does the buried subconscious surface, and one discovers oneself to be simply a sentimental individual like anybody else. At that point come the doubts: the wrong Guru, the wrong method of meditation; fear of death and of losing everything; sudden sharp pangs of family affection, stinging like a scorpion, once every support has been cut off; petty, irrational instincts surfacing in the very individual who thought he had renounced them, because he has starved his sentiments rather than resolved them; and the despondent question of whether God-realization is attainable in this birth at all, given decades of apparent non-progress.

The Ambush of the Subconscious

These subconscious forces find the seeker's weak point and ambush him there, leaving a helpless, petty individual for whom "God has not come; the world has gone" — a vacuum, belonging neither to the world nor to God. This condition can produce neurosis, breakdown, or psychosomatic illness such as a peptic ulcer or a deranged mind. One swami, having meditated for years on the presence of consciousness in all objects and having begun to perceive it everywhere with great happiness, was one day struck, in his own words, by "a bolt from the blue," and was left shaking his head, asking whether any remedy existed.

The Real Battle Is With the Mind

Arjuna must be prepared for this psychological ordeal, not merely the physical one — fighting the mind is harder than fighting people, because it is the mind that assigns the values "friend" and "enemy" in the first place. This valuation is not inherent in the other person but is a mould within the mind itself: without the mind's own susceptibility to affection and hatred, neither would be experienced. The weakness lies dormant in ordinary social life, where a good society keeps everything looking fine and the mechanism unprovoked, but it surfaces the moment one is entirely alone, when the previously ignored contents of the mind demand their due before any further progress is possible. Arjuna also asks whether even the best of seekers is guaranteed success, and what becomes of one who perishes mid-path, having attained nothing — a question Krishna answers later, elsewhere.

What Detachment Actually Means

Detachment does not mean physically fleeing society — not a literal departure from one's place for some remote wilderness. It means the mind's dissociation from social contact even while remaining physically present among people, as in a railway coach where many strangers share the same space — technically a "society" — yet one may remain wholly unconnected to and unaware of them. It is the mind, not the body, that works the havoc that must actually be addressed.

The World's Grip: Yudhishtira's Obeisance

Bhishma, Drona, and Karna were far stronger opponents than Arjuna, a fact that frames the following episode. Before the war, with both armies armed and ready, Yudhishtira set down his weapons, removed his shoes, put on a single cloth, and walked unarmed into the enemy ranks. Arjuna took his brother for mad; Duryodhana's side jeered him as a coward come to sue for peace. Krishna explained that Yudhishtira was neither: he was following the dharma of paying obeisance to elders. He prostrated before Bhishma and asked for his blessing toward victory; Bhishma refused it as long as he lived. Asked how success would then come, Bhishma deferred the question. The same exchange followed with Drona and with Kripacharya, each declining to bless Yudhishtira's success while still on the field.

This shows that the world does not release the seeker easily — it holds him through sentiment, desire, longing, and relationship. The gold, silver, milk and honey of the world are real satisfactions; the joy of being an important, wealthy, powerful person is not to be denied. So when the world extends its temptation — a gold throne, say — every seeker will hesitate. Christ was shown a field of gold and silver by Satan and urged to turn stone into bread and abandon further austerity for good works instead; the same temptation, in different form, was offered to Buddha — and will be offered to every seeker.

Arjuna as the Beginning of Spiritual Life

Arjuna epically represents the internal chaos of the beginning of spiritual life, not its advanced, positively attained stages: total confusion, a sense of having lost father, mother, friends, and guidance; sickness; the risk of going mad. Some seekers wander from place to place to avoid breaking down, as a long walk cools anger, but such tactics ultimately fail because one has not properly grounded oneself in a correct appreciation of values.

Is There a Rational Ground for Renunciation?

Who actually told us the world must be renounced? Elders say so; scripture says so; the Guru says so — but is there any rational ground for it beyond citing authority, any reason one has actually arrived at oneself? Very few can answer this; it is, in truth, a difficult question with no ready rational ground. When one is actually drowning, no scripture — neither the Bible nor the Gita — and no Guru comes to the rescue; only one's own conscience does.

Surrender to the Guru

Arjuna's crisis is thus a spiritual crisis: the epic depiction of chaos in an otherwise adventurous seeker who advances toward the battle of life and then collapses into diffidence, finding no help in japa, meditation, or the reading of scripture. His only resort is the Guru. He was fortunate — in having a competent Guru, in his own willingness to surrender, and in recognizing that his egoism could no longer serve him; had he clung to the arguments of the First Chapter, nothing would have come of it. A rise of sattvic karma led him instead to ask what he ought to do: "In this chaotic condition of my mind, what is my duty? I surrender myself to you, great Master. Please tell me."

Krishna's reply: Arjuna has drawn conclusions without understanding the structure of life and his relation to people and things; wrong premises yield wrong conclusions, so everything argued in the First Chapter stands without foundation, since Arjuna knows neither himself nor the world. The Second Chapter will explain the self; the Third, the world.